

The Politic

March 2020
Issue V
The Yale Journal of Politics and Culture

VIL-LAGE LOUD

The politics of discourse in Germany, five years after the refugee crisis

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The Politic

RIANNA TURNER 2 **OPEN CIRCLES**

Restorative justice practices spread in New Haven public schools

MADISON HAHAMY 7 **DORM STORM**

Yale's campus sees a flurry of political activity—but to what end?

IMAN IFTIKHAR 11 **EXECUTING JUSTICE**

Violence against children in Pakistan sparks debate on retribution

MAAYAN SCHOEN 16 **RIGHT TO RUN**

Ballot access laws across the country exclude third-party candidates

NISHI FELTON 21 **VILLAGE LOUD**

The politics of discourse in Germany, five years after the refugee crisis

GALL SIGLER 26 **LEBANESE FIRST**

Anti-corruption protests in Lebanon unite sectarian groups

ISIUWA OMOIGUI 31 **DO NO HARM**
staff writer

Reflecting on a legacy of pain for black women and girls in the United States

PAUL ROTMAN 37 **A CONVERSATION WITH ADMIRAL MICHAEL MULLEN**
staff writer

On Don't Ask, Don't Tell; the Obama administration; and the rules of intervention

Restorativ

practices sp

Haven publ

BY **RIANNA TURNER**

"I FEEL SAD."

"What color is that?"

The kindergartener—perching, like all the peers around him, on his bottom with incredible stillness for three in the afternoon—looks up at his teacher, who asked the question.

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"Blue," he answered.

"I feel happy, and yellow is happy for me," the next five year-old in the circle says. The class has just read a book in which a cartoon heart adopted a different color for every emotion. The students were instructed to share the color of their current emotion as part of a "Friday feeling check-in." The sharing student holds a popsicle stick with a stuffed owl hot-glued to the end. Happy Yellow Girl passes the owl, named Baby Earl, to her right.

"I feel silly."

"And what color would you use for silly?" the teacher asks. She leans forward, attentive and patient, showcasing the rhinestone brooch pinned to her collar.

"Light blue?" The girl, unsure, repeats the color the cartoon heart had ascribed to silliness.

"But what color would *you* like to use?"

The student looks down at the mat for a moment. It takes time to consider what one truly thinks "silly" looks like, especially at five years old. "Mm. Gold."

These community-building circles take place twice a day in Michelle Paulishen's class at the Edgewood School in New Haven. Each morning and afternoon, the students gather around a rug and divert their attention from academics to a social-emotional curriculum.

Training teachers to lead circle discussions like these is one of the ways in which New Haven Public Schools has implemented "restorative practices"—a set of social science tools that seek to improve and repair relationships between people and communities as well as create an empathetic school culture such as the one at Edgewood. The goal is to reduce suspensions and keep kids in school.

Some teachers and administrators in the district have been working to implement these strategies for five years now, but amid a lack of funding and district-wide buy-in, most of NHPS' gains have been disparate–attributable to the work being done by a few passionate individual actors.

RESTORATIVE PRACTICES is a community-centric philosophy that prioritizes mediation, accountability, and reconciliation. The strategy, long practiced among indigenous peoples, was popularized under the moniker "restorative practices" in the 1970s concurrent to growing sentiment in the Western world to challenge punitive justice systems; in the 1990s school districts began experimenting with the approach as an alternative to traditional disciplinary measures. Ultimately, restorative practices focus on bringing communities together after a harm has occurred instead of punishing an individual.

According to Randy Compton, CEO of school consultation and training organization Restorative Solutions, describing these tools as merely restorative can be misleading. He describes it as a process by which communities "create a culture where harm no longer has to exist."

Paulishen's daily community-building circles primarily serve the latter purpose by helping students learn how to articulate their feelings and describe them to others. At the Edgewood School, "restorative" circles, by contrast, only occur when a harm must be addressed, and are often initiated spontaneously. Earlier that Friday, a first-grader stepped off the bus in a huff to tell one of Paulishen's students that she was "no good at math." After taking note of her student's uncharacteristic lack of confidence, Paulishen asked the student if she would be willing to have a circle with the first grader. The first grader, who was initially preoccupied with whether he was in trouble, recognized the impact of his words and offered a sincere apology by the end of the conversation.

Due to restorative practices' relative nascence, studies show mixed results about its efficacy. According to a 2019 research review, every school studied saw decreases in overall suspension rates, but only schools in Oakland, California, and Denver–which saw the black-white discipline gap narrow from 9 percent to 5 percent–observed a decrease in the racial discipline gap.

According to Compton, these mixed results can be attributed to differences in implementation. Oakland and Denver administer the philosophy with persistence, recognizing that building a community among individuals of varying ages and backgrounds can be a three- to seven-year time investment. Other districts, however, fail to follow up after teachers are trained.

Sarah Miller, a volunteer with New Haven Public Schools Advocates and co-chair of Mayor-elect Justin Elicker's transition team, strongly supports restorative practices.

There are a wide variety of student needs, she explained, but restorative practices "addresses those needs all at once… If it's done well, it's transformative." Still, Miller cautioned, "it has to be done in the right way, and that takes commitment, and staff, and human time–and in a bureaucracy, human time costs money."

"Restorative ju about support, and accou

In her experience, although some detractors view restorative practices as "letting kids get away with nothing," the opposition–if any–typically occurs after half-baked implementation leads to disappointing results. "I haven't met anybody who's really opposed to it and really understands the implementation,"

said Miller.

"Our schools are cut to the bone," she explained, "we're doing this with our hands tied behind our backs." Partly, the district's financial troubles stem from the inability to tax $6 billion of Yale-owned land. "We don't have the tax base, and we can't tax New Haven any more. Yale is complicit in all of this, and that really doesn't get enough attention."

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THE INITIAL catalyst for New Haven's interest in restorative practices was a racial discipline gap. In a 2011–2012 Center for Civil Rights Remedies report, the district was cited as one of many across the country suspending black and Latino students at disproportionately high rates. Shortly afterward, newly-elected mayor Toni Harp made the issue central to her platform. This led to the teachers union's acquisition of a two-year, $300,000 grant intended for school discipline endeavors.

The union used the grant to train 37 teachers at the International Institute for Restorative Practices, a graduate school in Pennsylvania, after which they would return home and proselytize the curriculum.

In 2015, the grant's second and final year, Cameo Thorne, who had worked as a teacher in New Haven since 2000, took over as the district's Restorative Practices Coordinator. Indeed, according to Miller, "Cameo is one person trying to implement a whole culture shift."

According to Thorne, school board fluctuations stunted the district's progress mere months after she took over, and the superintendency became a revolving door, with four leaders helming the school system in three years.

During this pause in progress, Thorne and Paulishen spearheaded implementation. Administrators at John S. Martinez School worked to completely phase out suspensions by 2017. That year, Elm City Montessori replaced in-school-suspensions with a "reflection room," where students are asked to sit in a comfortable space and have a conversation about their actions.

According to teacher Nakisha Cadore, classroom removal at the school has declined by 43 percent since the change.

But implementation has been on a school-by-school basis, Cadore said. "[Some] schools are more stuck in their ways as far as how they should be managing behavior, but other schools are getting on board."

Cadore noted that many teachers and administrators across the district question whether students will change their behaviors in an absence of punishments that feel punitive. Some teachers also prefer the ability to remove or suspend a child when they are disruptive.

Miller has heard the explanation in discussions with teachers and parents: "You have teachers getting kicked, and bit, and even punched. You have really scary things happening. Not everywhere, but there are people who say, "If I have a kid bite me–they're going to be punished. We're not going to sit down and sing kumbaya."

This lack of buy-in among all schools and teachers led to the kinds of implementation issues being grappled with across the field. In January, the New Haven Board of Alders Education Committee presented a report detailing a decrease in overall suspensions across the district, but massive disparities in discipline across racial groups.

In the 2018-2019 school year, black students made up 60 percent of suspensions, Latino students 32 percent, and white students 7 percent. Black students only make up 19 percent of the district's population, making them the only demographic in which the average percentage of out-of-school suspensions is higher than their percentage of total student enrollment.

Sheryl Wilson, a practitioner who writes about the relationship between the restorative justice movement and racial reconciliation, touts anti-racism training as a necessary supplement to other training.

"As a mother who raised two African-American sons in public schools around the country, it's something I see," Wilson said. "I've seen great teachers miss the fact that they look at my child differently. But if people are implementing these practices with the same lens they've been using their entire educational careers, then their biases may go unchecked."

Wilson added that this is why implementation of restorative justice is not "one-and-done"–to find success, districts must continually evaluate their progress with professionals and readdress deeper issues. For a district like New Haven with a persistent racial

discipline gap, this may entail implicit bias training. Yet without whole-district buy-in and adequate funding, these issues may prove hard to shake.

Thorne is attempting to address this gap by writing restorative practices into the district's Code of Conduct. She hopes the board will soon approve the revised version to protect against future leadership fluctuations. Thorne also seeks to implement a liaison in each campus. Martinez School, which isn't suspending students of any race, has a trained climate professional on staff. The designated climate professional would be an existing member of each school's staff who feels passionate about these strategies. This teacher would help others conduct circles and be the primary point-of-contact on campus if problems arise, allowing Thorne to focus on training.

Paulishen also believes racial sensitivity training is necessary for New Haven teachers. When her son, unable to read in the second grade, was not tested for Special Education programs until her explicit request, she noted the disproportionate number of black students tested for these programs.

New Haven's lack of funding has also trickled to youth programs outside of the school system. The Boys and Girls Club is scheduled to close, and Project Youth Court has officially disbanded after years of being under-funded. This court, run almost entirely by teenagers, offered restorative "contracts" to juveniles to help them clear their records. These contracts included tasks like essay-writing and community service, allowing teenagers on equal footing to negotiate the tasks necessary for a member of their community to be re-integrated.

"People in New Haven talk the talk about restorative justice, but they don't walk the walk," said Jane Michaud, the former director of Project Youth Court. "It's hard to get people to change their thinking on kids who misbehave. Restorative justice is really about support, compassion, and accountability."

Compton said more people in the field need to think critically about how they're implementing the strategies if they seek to reduce racial disparities. "I think a lot of people go into this world thinking: Let's reduce suspensions, or reduce office referrals. We need to rethink what those goals are. We want to dive a little bit deeper to change the school culture and not just reduce discipline issues."

It may appear ironic that individuals have assumed the responsibility of carrying out a philosophy rooted in community buy-in, but these individuals are dedicated to the results they've seen. Thorne flies from campus to campus conducting teacher trainings. Former youth court participants are banding together to revive the program. Kermit Carolina, the district's supervisor of youth development, is mentoring young black boys in an after-school program of his own making. And in classrooms like Paulishen's, kindergarteners ask for time in the "Contemplation Corner," learning to talk through their emotions and relate to one another.

"To be fair, public education — it's underfunded and over-worked," Thorne said. Everybody's working more hours than their contract says. Everyone's facing more batting-cage situations every day, and they come back to work and do it again and again. Building a community of people that understands one another is going to give teachers relief."

Thorne has seen many teaching philosophies fail in her 15 years of teaching, but with restorative strategies, she is starting to see results. In one instance, Thorne conducted a circle with two students involved in the stealing of a phone. When Thorne asked the student without a phone how he was most affected by the loss, the student said he was unsure whether walking to the bus stop would be safe without a way to communicate with people in his neighborhood. After being given the chance to fully understand the consequences of his actions, the other student offered more money to replace the phone than was requested.

Students agree. New Haven surveyed students at all levels who participated in circle discussions, and many felt they had a better understanding of their peer's emotions and motives. Tamar Williams, a high school student at Career Regional, said the circles brought his class "together as a family."

"We would open up to one another and see a different side of each person that isn't often shown," Tamar wrote. "At times it was emotional, at times it was all laughs. I appreciated it a lot, one of the best things I've done in a classroom."

Although many members of Paulishen's kindergarten class are just learning to write their names, they record their opinion of the circles by choosing to opt-in, again and again. One student, concerned with the upcoming Thanksgiving break, looks up at his teacher.

"Will we still have a circle on a half-day?"



Dorm Storm

Yale's campus sees a flurry of political activity—but to what end?

BY **MADISON HAHAMY**

A KNOCK AT THE DOOR woke Spencer Hagaman '21. Still dazed from his interrupted nap, he wondered who could be trying to reach his suitemates on a Friday afternoon.

"It wasn't light tapping," Spencer said. "The oak doors in Franklin are very thick. It was definitely audible—it echoed through the room."

As soon as Spencer opened his door, he was greeted by a group of students brimming with enthusiasm that did not match his own sleepy reluctance. Some were wearing Bernie 2020 shirts. Others sported oversized campaign buttons reading "Bernie for America," or carried "I Wrote the Damn Bill!" flyers in hand. All carried an immovable conviction that their candidate is the best choice for America's 46th presidency, and they were



"Making connections with different people is part of politics—

determined to convert others.

"Hi, we're Students for Bernie," the group said, before introducing themselves individually. "Do you have a moment to talk about the 2020 election?"

"Dorm-storming" aims to reach voters where they are—literally—by bringing campaign literature to the doorsteps of Yale students. As the Democratic primary elections advance throughout the 50 states, groups like Yale for Bernie are experimenting with methods typically reserved for canvassing strangers. This student organizing tactic is not limited to Sanders supporters—Yale students have formed political groups campaigning on behalf of several different Democratic candidates, including Elizabeth Warren, Pete Buttigieg, and Amy Klobuchar.

With the road to the 2020 Democratic National Convention on July 13 still bumpy, student advocates hope that face-to-face conversations with their peers will compel them to reconsider their preexisting political affiliations.

Both the Democratic primary and the general election give greater influence to some states than others, making it strategically difficult to canvass students from all over the country. Student advocates have spent hours telling peers that their voices matter.

But to many busy Yalies like Spencer, who often have already decided their vote, the strategic end of these strenuous efforts is often unclear. "I kind of just nodded along and agreed with them for a little while, and after about five minutes or so they left."

THE FRIENDLY COMPETITION between Democratic canvassers began as soon as the Class of 2023 stepped on campus.

The fall extracurricular bazaar is notoriously overwhelming, even when students are not preparing for an election year. Amid the claustrophobic arrangement of student groups recruiting new members and the cacophony of underclassmen navigating the tables, advocates hoped to turn first-years to an issue beyond Yale: national politics.

Eva Quittman '23, a first-year member of Students for Bernie, admitted her lack of political engagement before coming to Yale's campus. However, upon arrival, her peers' advocacy persuaded her to become involved. In an interview with *The Politic*, Eva said, "A friend of mine who was in Morse and also a first-year had gotten involved with Students for Bernie, so I got involved when I saw them at the extracurricular fair."

For many campus groups, emphasizing political primaries is a key way to recruit members. Both first-years newly acquainted with politics at Yale and older students whose time on campus has been shaped by the Trump administration have felt the need to make their voices heard.

As Liam Elkind '21, Elections Coordinator for the Yale College Democrats, explained, "We spent our entire college career living under this presidency and so the ability to actually have a voice now...is essential. We are emphasizing [the 2020 elections] in our recruitment strategy."

Student organizations have crafted campaign strategies aimed at both increasing their own coalitions' membership and convincing students that their personal political preferences help determine the nation's political trajectory. Groups' method of advocacy is two-fold: asking students to refine their ideological convictions and register to vote. These intentions

have led to a wide range of methods, including hosting debate watch parties, tabling in student libraries and dining halls, and knocking on doors. Their actions remain guided by the belief that this advocacy will help reorient Yale's political compass.

AFTER EVERY CAMPAIGN event he attends, Trent Spiner, a reporter for *Politico*, gives his phone number to at least a dozen attendees. The morning of January 14, his phone would not stop buzzing. Just the night before, Sanders and Warren, the latter of whom has since dropped out of the race, engaged in a now-infamous debate exchange. Warren alleged that Sanders expressed sexist beliefs in a private December 2018 meeting. "I thought a woman could win," she said on the stage. "[Sanders] disagreed."

National news capitalized on the confrontation, citing it as evidence that the campaigns' mutual respect had disintegrated. Media outlets portrayed it as the end of an uneasy alliance between "Bernie Bros" and "Warren Warriors."

To Spiner, the feud is indisputably genuine. He pointed to increasing animosity between Sanders and Warren supporters following the debate as evidence. Many Sanders supporters blamed Warren for playing the "woman card" and expressed reluctance towards voting for her. On the other hand, Spiner claims some Warren supporters would not be "voting for an old white guy" and hold Sanders accountable for the sexist comment.

On Yale's campus, however, this kind of reaction was hardly noticeable. Jordan Cozby '20, former co-president of Yale Students for Warren, didn't see a "drastic shift" in campus dialogue in response to Warren's allegations. For better or worse, most students at Yale seemed to be focused on policy and ideological differences between the candidates, rather than Sanders' and Warren's rhetorical tit-for-tat.

"I'm typically resistant to the 'media manufacturing' arguments," Jordan said. "I don't think that they have the nuance to do so." Instead, he thinks that media behavior is more indicative of a state of discourse in which "the loudest voices are those which are heard clearest."

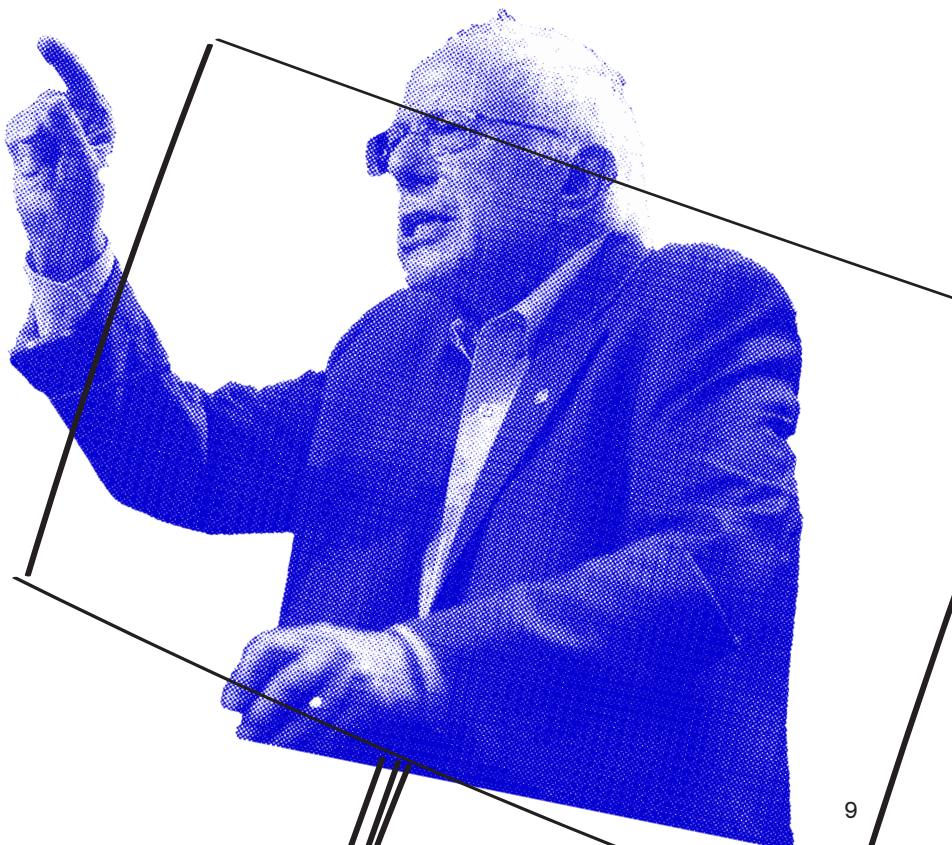
David Edimo '21, the other former Yale Students for Warren co-president, agreed, pointing to Warren and Sanders' friendship as evidence that "the extent to which [the feud] illustrates a rift has been way overplayed. At the end of the day, most people who support [one] candidate will be willing to vote for the other candidate."

According to Ryan Dougherty FES '21, a founding member and campus organizer for Yale Students for Bernie, ideological differences between Sanders and Warren often do not play a major role in students' "rank-order preferences" of major contenders for the Democratic nomination.

"I've canvassed a few dorms now: Warren supporters will usually say that they actually like Bernie, and Bernie supporters will say that they like Warren," Ryan said.

Nonetheless, Ryan believes that there are enough "substantial differences" even between candidates with

getting to know people who are different from you."





similar platforms, including Sanders and Warren, to warrant an informed discussion about students' political and ideological preferences. For instance, many Sanders supporters say that foreign policy is the main reason for their choice, while some Warren supporters prioritized her policies on childcare and universal education.

It is unclear whether the media has overstated the division in the electorate between Sanders and Warren, or if college students simply have different priorities compared to the general public when choosing a nominee.

In response to assertions that the feud is overblown, Spiner explained, "It's easy for someone at Yale to sit on campus and pontificate about what they think is happening, but there's a difference between opinion and fact, which is what reporters are tasked to discover."

ON FEBRUARY 8TH, members of the Yale College Democrats piled into a bus headed for New Hampshire to canvass for the candidate of their choice—three Buttigieg supporters signed up, 15 for Sanders, and 53 for Warren. Liam shared that the motivation for campaigning in New Hampshire was partially due to New Hampshire's status as an early primary state.

"It holds this prized position above all the other states as a bellwether for who has momentum, who has strength, [and] who has strong organizing capabilities," he said. Liam also emphasized the relative urgency of the New Hampshire primary, stating that despite the late primary date in Connecticut, students "wanted to get started early."

This year's Connecticut primary is on April 28th, almost three months after the Iowa caucus that kicked off the Democratic primary season.

Connecticut's 60 Democratic delegates will be apportioned after 2,794 delegates from other states are already determined. While most students can vote in their home states with absentee ballots, Yale's geographically diverse student body makes mobilizing students difficult, since election dates are scattered throughout the upcoming months.

Indeed, some Yale voters from early or swing states have strategically focused on their home elections rather than Connecticut's.

Bryce Morales '23, a student from New Hampshire, shared that canvassing and political action at Yale somewhat informed his voting decision but only because he actively sought political engagement on campus. In a conversation with *The Politic*, Bryce described his experiences phone banking with the Yale for Pete campaign organizers. He also emphasized "a long conversation" with an organizer from Yale Students for Bernie about his personal transition from supporting Sanders in 2016 to Buttigieg in 2020.

To Eva, campaigning in Connecticut is important too: "Every state matters," she said. "Even though they're not the first state in the primary, every state has a say in the political process. We want to be sure that people are voting for a candidate they have confidence in."

Ultimately, Eva sees her efforts with Yale Students for Bernie as extending beyond the Sanders campaign. "It transcends just this one person, very much a movement and a set of ideas that will carry forward throughout time."

Liam and the Yale Democrats left New Hampshire feeling confident that they had made their voices heard, but they're not done yet. They plan to head to Philadelphia in March to register voters for the upcoming House election and to continue canvassing for their preferred candidates. "Traveling is fun," Liam said, "and it's exciting to talk to voters who aren't from where you are. Making connections with different people is part of politics—getting to know people who are different from you."

AT THE END OF THE DAY, students agree that the differences—though important—don't run too deep.

"As they operate on campus," Jordan explained, "these campaigns... are really motivated to defeat Donald Trump and [bring about] systemic change." He sees Sanders and Warren as having each been possible standard-bearers of a progressive future, but "think[s] people will unify [behind] whoever wins the nomination."

Ryan, for one, "prefer[s] Bernie quite a lot." He didn't need to pause, though, before continuing: "But my God, I want Donald Trump out of office."



CW: violence, sexual violence, child abuse

EXECUTING JUSTICE

BY **IMAN IFTIKHAR**

VIOLENCE AGAINST CHILDREN IN PAKISTAN SPARKS DEBATE ON RETRIBUTION

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You stay awake and pray at night,
The dogs are also awake,
They are superior to you.

They never stop barking,
And go and sleep on a pile of rubbish,
They are superior to you."

- "Dogs stay up at night,"
Bulleh Shah

KASUR, A CITY KNOWN for its patron saint—the Sufi poet, Bulleh Shah—has, in recent years, become Pakistan's by-word for child abuse. Witnessed only by Shah's nocturnal dogs, at least 12 bodies of underage victims of rape and subsequent murder were found in 2018 alone, dumped unceremoniously within a 6.5-mile radius of a garbage disposal in this small, industrial city in Pakistan's Punjab province.

Zainab Ansari, a bright-eyed six-year-old girl, was one of these victims. On January 4, 2018, Zainab, who had been on her way to a Qur'an recital class earlier that day, was declared missing. Five days later, her body was discovered in a trash pile near Shahbaz Khan road, only about 300 feet from her own house. Zainab's case sparked national uproar. While protestors flooded streets and engaged in violent police clashes, a tide of hashtags demanding #JusticeforZainab overtook social media. Amid these enraged calls for justice emerged a unified stance. Only one statement remained on everyone's lips: Hang the accused.

Imran Ali, a 26-year-old man, was found guilty of Zainab's murder and those of seven other girls. He was tried on multiple counts of kidnapping, rape, and murder, and charged with four death penalties, life imprisonment, and 31,000 dollars in fines by Pakistan's anti-terror court. Rejecting appeals for a public execution, the court hanged Ali on October 17, 2018 in Kot Lakhpat Jail, Lahore.

In Kot Lakhpat on execution day, Amin Ansari, Zainab's aggrieved father, shared with local news channels: "No matter what, in my opinion, our family would have been more content had [Ali] been made a public spectacle. The entire country would have watched, and it would have been a lesson for those who commit such crimes."

"WE HAVE SEEN it ourselves. Public executions, even capital punishment, do not work as an effective deterrent for cases of child abuse. Imran Ali was hanged post the Zainab case, [and the] number of child abuse cases has only risen since," Imtiaz Somra, a Pakistani lawyer who has worked extensively on child abuse cases as the head of a legal aid collective in the country, said in an interview with *The Politic*.

While there are modern disagreements about the efficacy of capital punishment as a deterrent, the method has a long history within the Pakistani justice system. In 1981, then-General Zia-ul-Haq hanged the rapists and murderers of a young boy named Pappu on the 18th of January. As the sun set and the Maghrib call to prayer began blasting from the speakers of local mosques, the bodies of Pappu's killers hung from wooden posts in central Lahore, with tens of thousands flocking to watch the scene.

Whether or not the 1981 execution worked to discourage child abuse is a matter of great debate in Pakistan. Many quote a dip in numbers of reported cases after the public execution to argue that the deterrent had worked. Others, however, see this as a result of the state censorship of government-produced data by a dic-

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tatorship actively invested in defending this form of justice. Instead, many highlight alternative data from the Human Rights Committee that show ten such cases reported in Lahore alone in 1981 questioning the statistics on child abuse reform that the government has put forth. When General Zia was assassinated in 1988, public executions in Pakistan came to an end.

Manizeh Bano is the Executive Director of Sahil, one of Pakistan's only NGOs working to protect children in the region and collecting statistics on the number of incidents that take place from local newspapers. In a video interview with *The Politic*, Bano said that "A public hanging would only brutalize the spectators and the general public. They would be desensitized, when in actuality, issues of such nature require humans to be more sensitive towards the stakeholders."

OVER A YEAR after Imran Ali was executed, Kasur, and the rest of Pakistan, remains haunted. Numbers of reported cases of child abuse have only grown. In 2018, according to Sahil, 3,832 cases of child abuse were reported in Pakistan. Accounts by Lahore Press Club count 1,304 cases of sexual exploitation of children under the age of 18 between January and June of 2019. Reports from the latter half of the year have not yet been added to the published statistics. The execution that was supposed to relieve the Pakistani people of their grief has not prevented them from experiencing new losses.

Two years after her own daughter's smiling photograph—Zainab bedecked in a pink, bomber jacket, matching pins in her hair—became the nation's most circulated picture on the internet, Nusrat Amin solemnly reflected in an interview with the BBC: "Nothing has changed. As soon as you turn the TV on, you see cases similar to ours. Their names and pictures are different, but to me it seems as though they are all Zainab."

On May 20, 2019, following a similar trajectory to the Zainab case, a new smiling six-year-old girl's pictures began circulating through Twitter. Raped and tortured, Farishta Nabi's body was found in Islamabad. Following Farish-

ta, the news media rattled once again in September 2019 when Muhammad Faizan, Ali Husnain, and two other unnamed young boys were found victim to the same crimes in Chunian, in the Kasur District. What remains for these countless young kids are inconsolable parents, tattered clothes, TV-popular identification pictures, and a nationwide cry for a public hanging.

In Pakistan, the demand for public executions is not a last resort. Various members of Pakistani society recognize discrepancies and issues in the system which should be addressed prior to resorting to capital punishment. The Pakistani public blames different actors for systematic insufficiencies, including the government, media, culture, and even poor parenting.

Agha Nasir Mahmood, a police inspector and specialist in child abuse cases in Punjab, explained in an interview with *The Politic* that the families of victims are often slow to report cases to the police and instead choose to conduct a preliminary search by themselves. According to him, ideas of *izzat*, which means honor in Urdu, force Pakistanis to shy away from reporting cases due to the shame of being raped in a heavily patriarchal society. Mahmood considers this "contributory violence." He was willing, however, to recognize the police's own inefficiencies. "This is two-pronged: The parent's unsurety in reporting cases and the police's half-heartedness in conducting an investigation often cause a 36 hour limbo period, which in such cases is deadly."

Families of victims blame the police. Farishta's family informed local news outlets that before starting the investigation, police officers suggested that their six-year-old daughter might have secretly eloped. The family had to perform errands—a common Pakistani practice—in exchange for police services to investigate the case. In another case, local police found a man known only to the media as "Mudassar," allegedly responsible for the murders of Iman Fatima and over half a dozen other children in Kasur. Mudassar, who was later found to be wrongly accused, was shot by the police in an extrajudicial killing, possibly in an attempt to satisfy popular frustration with investigative authorities.

In an interview with *The Politic*, Deputy Superintendent of the Lahore Police Department, Muhammad Anwar addressed complaints: "We are using the most modern technology and conducting our best efforts. You know how sensitive the issue is, why would a police officer ever want to deliberately delay an investigation?"

Apart from issues with the local police administration, many find Pakistani state departments and government to be liable. Somra stated that "Pakistan, alongside other countries in the subcontinent, is a signatory of the United Nations Child Rights Convention of 1989, yet not one of the convention's 42 articles has been thoroughly implemented in the region." He continued, "The government does not see this as a primary concern and keeps pushing this issue to the periphery. They make it seem as though there are no laws in Pakistan. Pakistan has laws, thousands of them. The issue is in their implementation. In order for there to be a change in society, the state will need to take an active stance."

Indeed, although Child Protection and Welfare Bureau Punjab Chairperson Sarah Ahmed publicly argued that the issue is a lack of legislation in Pakistan in the aftermath of the Kashur cases, history indicates that the issue extends further than law. In 2015, after the breakup of a child pornography ring in Kasur which victimized hundreds of children, the Pakistani government tightened laws on child pornography, including proposing a seven-year sentence for the crime.

None of these laws seem to yield change. Somra added, "Laws only work when they are implemented. There are strict laws against child labor in Pakistan. Kids no older than 10 are making bangles in Hyderabad, selling balloons in the streets in Lahore, working in the fields in virtually all rural areas. Why do you think this is so?"

Many also point out that such incidents are not limited to the Kasur region, but rather plague the entire country. However, specific attention is only given to Punjab by the media, thus causing outrage in this particular area and leaving the rest of the country in the shadows. Somra stated, "This is all because of the media. The media brings the cases in Punjab to the limelight. There are probably thousands of such cases in Balochistan. However, there is no media attention there."

Despite Pakistanis' widespread acknowledgement that the system has shortcomings—such as drawbacks in police investigations, political inattentiveness, and the continuation of societal taboos about honor—support for public hangings remains unchanged. Mahmood, the police inspector, said, "I am a father myself. If someone were to commit such a brutal act against my daughter, I would settle for nothing short of a public hanging."

The millions in Pakistan who back capital punishment, including public hangings, speak of matching

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the intensity of the punishment with the gravity of the crime. The question remains, however, of the intention behind the use of such a strict punishment. Is the death sentence, and call for public hangings, a demand for retributive justice? Is a desire for vengeance fueling a mob mentality? Or is it a failure of the legal system which purports to be rehabilitative?

Among calls for public hangings and the continued support for capital punishment by the majority, one factor remains: There are issues in the Pakistani justice, legal, policing, and government systems which have not been addressed. A public hanging seems, in light of this fact, a hasty attempt to fix an otherwise deep-running problem.

FOR WHAT SEEMS a sad reality with no potential for betterment, there is still hope, according to Sahil's Bano. "For us, these rising numbers of reported cases are a positive indicator," she told *The Politic*. "It means people are starting to recognize the importance of reporting, or going through with legal proceedings." According to her, both government institutions and local nonprofits have expressed a desire for change. "Laws have been streamlined in the recent past. The government has taken a step ahead in clearly defining laws around age, type of abuse, [and other characteristics]."

But the work is far from over. "We need child-friendly cops, the potential for video recording survivor's statements so they do not have to attend courts and face their abuser, psychological aid for survivors, as well as victim's families, and so many other improvements. Implementation of laws also remains a major concern," Bano said. "However, we are seeing positive reactions to our work in local, rural communities. People recognize the intensity of the issue, and they are willing to make changes."

She added, "The death penalty, and public hangings, are the angry outcries of a devastated public. What we need in Pakistan is to hang onto hope."

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Right to Run

Ballot access laws across the country exclude third-party candidates

BY **MAAYAN SCHOEN**

"THE HARDEST THING TO DO is walk up to somebody and ask for a signature—not even to vote for me, just for a signature," recalled former Marine Corps Sergeant James Hall in an interview with *The Politic*. He recounted the discomfort clearly, even though it had been almost seven years since he had run as an independent candidate in an Alabama special election for the House of Representatives.

He was already uncomfortable approaching strangers' doors to ask for the confusing favor. Hall had to explain to those worried citizens who let him in that signing was not a commitment to vote for him but would just help secure him a spot on the ballot. In over five thousand homes, he repeated the explanation to anyone who would listen.

Hall's opportunity had come in mid-2013, when Republican Congressman Jo Bonner of Alabama's First Congressional District announced early plans to resign in order to take a job at University of Alabama. Hall, who considers himself "a political outsider" unrepresented by either major party, believed this might be the only chance he had to serve as a candidate "for all of us who aren't represented." In regular elections in Alabama, the incumbent Democrat or Republican or a successor of their choosing usually wins, but Bonner did not immediately endorse another candidate. Hall recalled thinking, "There might not be a better time."

He had only three months from the date that the logistics of the the special election were announced to satisfy requirements for an independent to get on the ballot. Hall had to collect signatures from at least three percent of the number of citizens who voted in the most recent governor's race—a total of about 6,000. Alabama's Secretary of State, James R. Bennett, claimed ("disingenuous[ly]," Hall remarked with a snort) that the policy is fair because of the virtually unlimited

amount of time a prospective candidate has to collect signatures before a future regular election.

Though surrounding states suspend signature requirements for special elections, instead requiring from zero to a maximum of 100 signatures, Alabama law provides special elections no such exceptions, one example of a broader system aimed to preserve the two-party system.

But Hall wouldn't make the cut by the September deadline–and he wouldn't get to check his name off in the voting booth.

THIS PROCESS IS NO MISTAKE. Republican- and Democrat-run state legislatures can control who can and cannot be on a ballot—and have every incentive to utilize that power. All 50 states have laws that favor the entrenchment of Democratic and Republican parties, many of which have been on the books for more than a century. These laws come under meaningful challenge regularly, usually during urgent timeframes when lowercase-i independent or small party candidates want to run but meet insurmountable obstacles.

In an interview with *The Politic*, *Ballot Access News* editor Richard Winger noted that although voting rights in the country progressively improve, changes in ballot access have mostly been for the worse.

Winger traces difficulties for independent and small party candidates in ballot access back to 1889, when the Massachusetts government switched from the then-popular practice of candidates distributing their own ballots to a system in which the government printed standardized ballots.

Today's two-party silencing of independent candidates and small parties, he explained, solidified during the 20th century. Under President Wilson and concurrent to rapidly-spreading communism in the Soviet Union in the late 1910s, some states specifically banned the Communist Party by name or required all parties to sign an oath saying that they didn't support the Communist-endorsed violent overthrow of the government. Again during The Great Depression, state governments ramped up efforts to constrain small parties considered to have Communist leanings. These ultimately had the effect of limiting all parties outside the mainstream.

The 1931 Illinois full-slate law, for example, required any minor party wishing to run one candidate to present a candidate for *every* office on the ballot—an often insurmountable hurdle. A federal appeals court only recently struck that law, in 2017.

Another wave of laws limiting ballot access came in the 1960s in response to the unprecedented success of independent presidential candidate George Wallace—known at the time as a notorious racist and segregationist—who captured a shocking 13 percent of the vote. Winger explained, "A lot of well-meaning Democrats and Republicans saw how well Wallace had done and made ballot access laws to prevent that kind of thing from happening."

Bill Redpath, former Treasurer and Chair of the Libertarian Party's National Committee and a current At-

"Although voting rights in the country progressively improve, changes in ballot access have mostly been for the worse."

Large Representative, explained in an interview with *The Politic* that repression of independent and small party candidates has created a system in which it is often difficult for citizens to cast meaningful votes. Voters must often choose between the candidate they really want to vote for and someone they may see as the "lesser of two evils" between the Democratic and Republican candidates.

"WHEN MARINES GET FOOD in the field," Hall recalled, "the lowest-ranked Marine eats first. The highest ranked easts last." To him, that's how it should be. But the government, he believes, works the opposite way: It is made up of a "political elite," a "separate class" removed from the average person's experience.

Hall tried everything he could in the months before the deadline, aided by the work ethic and determination he credits to his time in the marines. After hours working to get signatures, he would plead with Bennett to reduce the number of signatures required.

He was not alone. Alabama has not had an independent candidate in a special election since 1893, when the state first began printing ballots in line with Massachusetts' lead. *Ballot Access News* argues this hints at a constitutional issue: In two 1970s cases, the Supreme Court found that independents never running is indicative that the barriers to running are too high. Indeed, in 1964 the Supreme Court ruled in *Reynolds v. Sims* that that "the right to vote freely for the candidate of one's choice is of the essence of society, and any restrictions on that right strike at the heart of representative government."

Despite what a federal judge referred to as Hall's "Herculean effort," it would have been impossible to collect 6,000 signatures in three months—especially while he kept his full-time job as a production supervisor for the business services Cintas Company.

The hurdles did not end there. In the run-up to elections, political organizers often prevent potential independent and small party candidates from participating in debates and other significant voter-education opportunities, based on the argument that these potential candidates will not make it onto the ballot.

> **"You've got to be in one of the two clubs to participate…. That restricts access, if you want to boil it down to the simplest point."**

Alabama Secretary of State John Merrill explained in an interview with *The Politic* that the ballot access laws just simplify the process: an independent candidate who falls short of the signature threshold won't win the race anyway. "Let's say 51,000 [signatures] is the accurate number. Both the Democratic candidate and the Republican candidate in our state will get more than 51,000 straight-ticket votes. So, [an independent] has absolutely no chance, period, to win."

In 2016, Hall filed a petition against Merrill for limiting his right to run and was joined in his suit by N.C. "Clint" Moser Jr., who initially sought to run as an independent candidate but managed to collect only 750 signatures. Moser was joined by Joshua



Cassity, then the Chairman of the Constitution Party of Alabama, who had decided not to run a candidate, experience telling him that ballot access would prove futile. Both filed sworn declarations on behalf of Hall.

Hall, Moser, and Cassity–like Winger–do not claim that no requirements should exist for candidates to be on the ballot. Rather, they are concerned about specific laws which make running near-impossible. Redpath calls these laws "utterly ridiculous, un-American, and anti-democracy."

ALABAMA'S BALLOT ACCESS LAWS are notoriously among the country's worst, but they are not the only ones. As recently as 2019, the Supreme Court refused to hear a case challenging a California law that requires independent presidential candidates to collect 200,000 signatures in 105 days. A Delaware law prevented an independent from being appointed to most judicial posts was contested by a former registered Democrat whom the state claimed was guilty of "self-injury" for leaving the party also went to the highest court: After losing the case at the 3rd Circuit, Delaware went to the extreme of appealing to the Supreme Court in an effort to keep the law on the books. This January, nine progressive Democrats signed "An Open Letter to the Green Party for 2020," urging the party not to campaign for president.

Obstacles vary in method and severity by state. The list of creative barriers enacted by states to exclude independent and small-party candidates is extensive, including exorbitant filing fees, early filing deadlines, and Alabama's law charging only minor parties $34,000 to get a copy of the state's voter registration list—a vitally important tool for every stage of the campaign. In some states, small parties need to get 20 percent of the vote every two years to stay on the ballot, which is arguably as important as getting on the ballot in the first place.

When asked whether independent party candidates face any notable obstacles in getting on the ballot, Merrill responded, "Oh, absolutely not." He explained that those candidates who failed to gain signatures simply weren't qualified to begin with: "To run a competitive race, you have to be eligible to run a competitive race–and that's by having the necessary financial resources and field support to show your electability."

Merrill is joined by staunch defenders of stringent ballot access laws, who argue that these laws are in the best interest of the state that passes them by limiting ballot-crowding and voter confusion. But according to ballot access law challengers, such as Hall, "you've got to be in one of the two clubs to participate…. That restricts access, if you want to boil it down to the simplest point."

WHEN THE SECRETARY OF STATE filed a motion to dismiss Hall's case, a federal trial court in the state rejected the motion. The court recognized that Hall's circumstances fell within the "capable of repetition, yet evading review" exception, without which election law could rarely be changed. In an historic victory, following years of litigation, Hall originally triumphed over Alabama's ballot access laws in an early suit, but the U.S. Court of Appeals for the 11th Circuit reversed, by a two-to-one decision, in 2018. The dissenting judge wrote, "No other court in the country" would have ruled as the 11th Circuit majority had just done.

Many of the decisions upholding stringent ballot access laws rely on *Jenness v. Fortson*, a 1971 case in which the Supreme Court upheld Georgia's signature and early deadline requirements that complainants argued was unconstitutional. Courts rely on *Jenness* in knee-jerk fashion.

According to Winger, *Jenness* was a flawed decision that has "made it possible for state legislators to cripple minor parties and independent candidacies." Only four minor parties have polled even three percent for president in the past 100 years, and no

> **"The system still feels stacked against people without boundless financial resources or party backing."**

minor party has had a seat in Congress in decades. Had *Jenness* always been in effect, according to Winger, it would have prevented the likes of Theodore Roosevelt, the Progressive Party nominee, from running for office.

"Governmental stability in a country like the United States is not dependent on any particular set of ballot access laws, much less on restrictive or discriminatory ballot access laws," said Winger. He hopes that 2020 will present an opportunity for voters to look outside the two major parties. "When a person who would be happy with [Michael] Bloomberg winning the nomination would be devastated if Bernie Sanders won, it's wrong for them to be in the same party," he said.

Redpath agrees. "It's completely unnatural to try to cram everyone into one of two big tents," he explained. "The world is too complicated. There are too many issues on which people differ to have a two-party system."

HALL SOUNDS TIRED through the phone. He still feels cheated by a system he sees as skewed towards the establishment. "You tell me how that's set up to represent everybody."

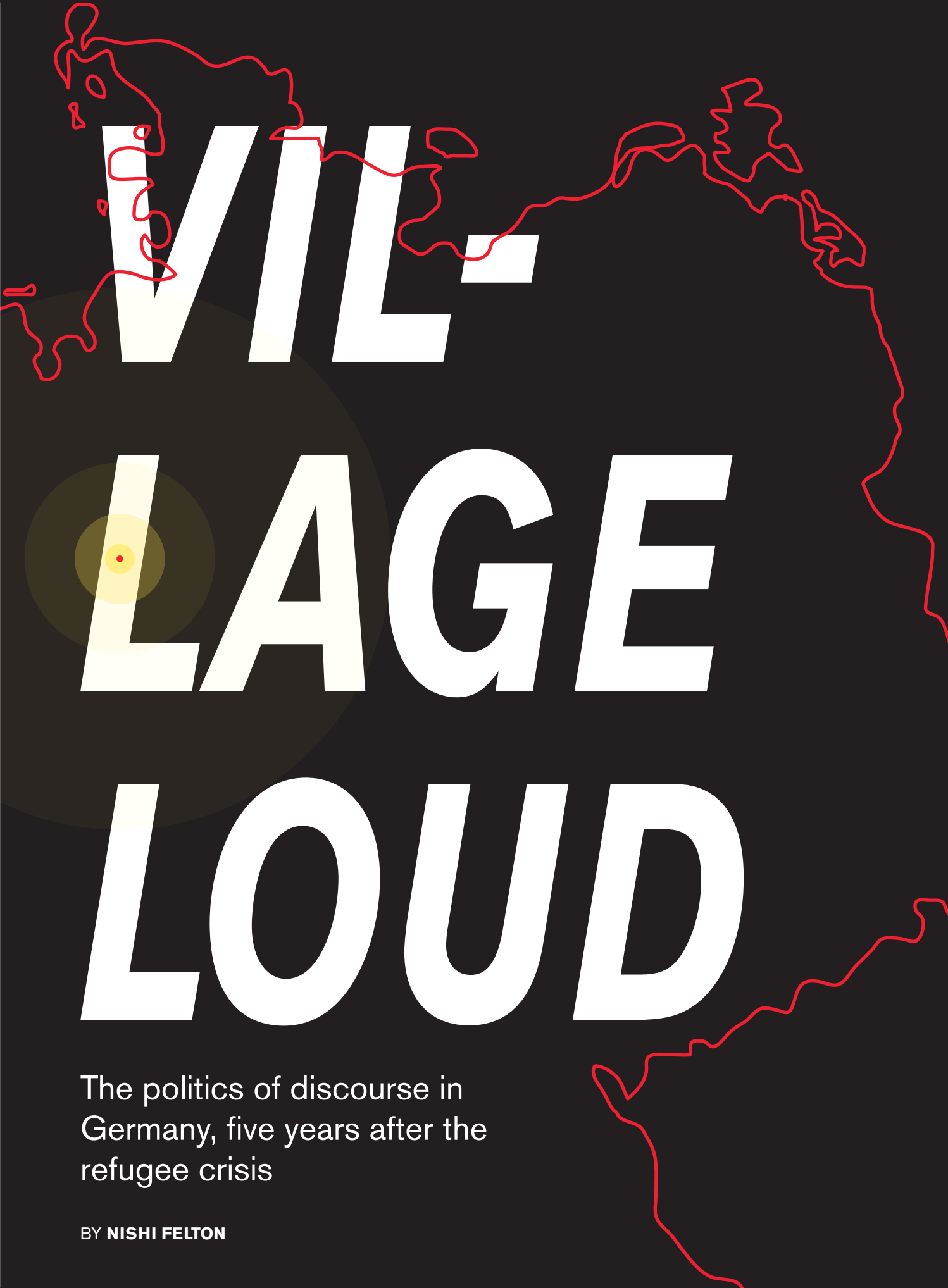
Redpath, who notably led the Libertarian Party to achieving ballot access for the presidential ticket in all 50 states in two consecutive elections, still believes that however disheartening the result, Hall's effort had some benefit. Minor parties should run, even for offices they "can't win," he explained, in order to "speak out on the great issues of the day."

Amendments to ballot access law happen all the time and mostly slip past an unaware public, even when they are dramatic. In December, 2019, for example, the New York State legislature amended its election laws to require 45,000 signatures for statewide independent candidates to gain ballot access—three times the number previously required. Only a few outlets, including *Ballot Access News* and the online forum *Ballotpedia*, report regularly on these changes.

But there are still some legal victories in the midst of these troubling changes. A U.S. District Court struck down the Michigan statewide signature requirement of 30,000 signatures. Kentucky struck down the law that requires independent candidates and the nominees of small parties to file early declarations of candidacy.

Hall is dubious about running again—he hasn't yet forgotten the time, money, and signature-soliciting required in his first attempt. The system still feels stacked against people without boundless financial resources or party backing. "If we're ever going to put regular people into our federal government, we've got to make access for regular people [to run]," he said. Until the laws change, he won't be ready to put himself out there again.





VIL-LAGE LOUD

The politics of discourse in Germany, five years after the refugee crisis

BY **NISHI FELTON**

By the end of the year, the country had accepted over 1 million asylum seekers.

"SCHAUMBURG IS, and remains, red! Marx·Engels·Stalin·Lenin·Mao," reads the graffiti on this side of the bridge. Each name is punctuated with a sickle and hammer. It is out of place in placid Vehlen, formerly in West Germany. When I ask Holger Meier—a local—about the graffiti, he laughs and says he has no idea who wrote it. "It was probably some teenagers. Marx and Lenin have never had much of a shot here."

Vehlen, where my mother grew up, is an unobtrusive village in Schaumburg, a district of about 150,000 people in the state of Lower Saxony. Outside the local church, a stone commemorates the village's founding in the year 1055. Branching off from the highway are cobbled streets and old houses in the half-timbered style for which North Germany is famous. Up the road is Obernkirchen, the small town which has subsumed Vehlen as it has grown. With an economy heavily reliant on sandstone mining, Obernkirchen has traditionally voted Social Democrat, but like much of the country, the area boasts somewhat surprising variation in its voting habits.

I visited Vehlen in December, five years after the refugee crisis of 2015. Its residents are concerned with local issues, but, like in all of Germany, a new mode of political engagement is obvious here. Politics have changed, revealing preferences that liberal Germans have become complacent about in the 30 years since reunification.

The Communist declaration has been on display for those who drive past it on the B65, a major regional road, for the past six months, yet no one in Vehlen seems inclined to remove it.

WHEN CLAUDIA KORNBLUM-ILLGNER moved to Vehlen 25 years ago, the issue on everybody's lips was the war in what used to be Yugoslavia. Kornblum-Illgner, a teacher in adult education and a translator, is measured and pleasant as she explains in an interview with *The Politic*, "Our neighbors could explode when you talked about politics." Although she had moved from Bielefeld, where political engagement and demonstrations are more common, she recalls that in Vehlen, conversations around the breakfast table often turned into heated debates on foreign affairs. "But that was just what you talked about," according to Kornblum-Illgner. Politics were not yet tainted by pessimism.

2015 changed that. By the end of the year, the country had accepted over 1 million asylum seekers. Though the largest influx was to the major cities, particularly Berlin, Merkel's open-door policy was evident even in Germany's rural centers. Heike Reyes-Küpper, a nurse, felt the effects of an increased population in the hospital where she works. "I saw it in the hospital—how many refugees we had coming [to Schaumburg]. And underlying all of that was always the question, how many can we take in?"

When refugees first arrived, everyone was welcoming. *Willkommenskultur*—a culture of welcome—became so

ubiquitous among German speakers that year that it was elected word of the year in Austria. But Kornblum-Illgner had her misgivings at the time. Perhaps, she suggests, "people didn't understand that [the refugees] weren't just passing through." Others, such as Meier, said that the problem lay in the perception of refugees as in need of undeserved charity. His neighbor, who volunteered at one of the shelters, told him, "The first thing they asked for was Wi-Fi and plug-in points to charge their smartphones."

SUPPORT FOR REFUGEES was and continues to be largely run by volunteers. Structural help from the government could not cope with the numbers, and though there are glory stories, the overwhelming attitude towards refugee politics today is *Verdrossenheit*—mistrust and disaffection.

Two years after the worst of the crisis, a new party had risen to power in Germany's historically two-party parliamentary system. Alternative for Germany (AfD), the first nationalist right-wing party to win seats since the Second World War, won enough votes in 2017 to surpass the five percent requirement for representation in Parliament, growing farther and faster than any other of the small parties had in years.

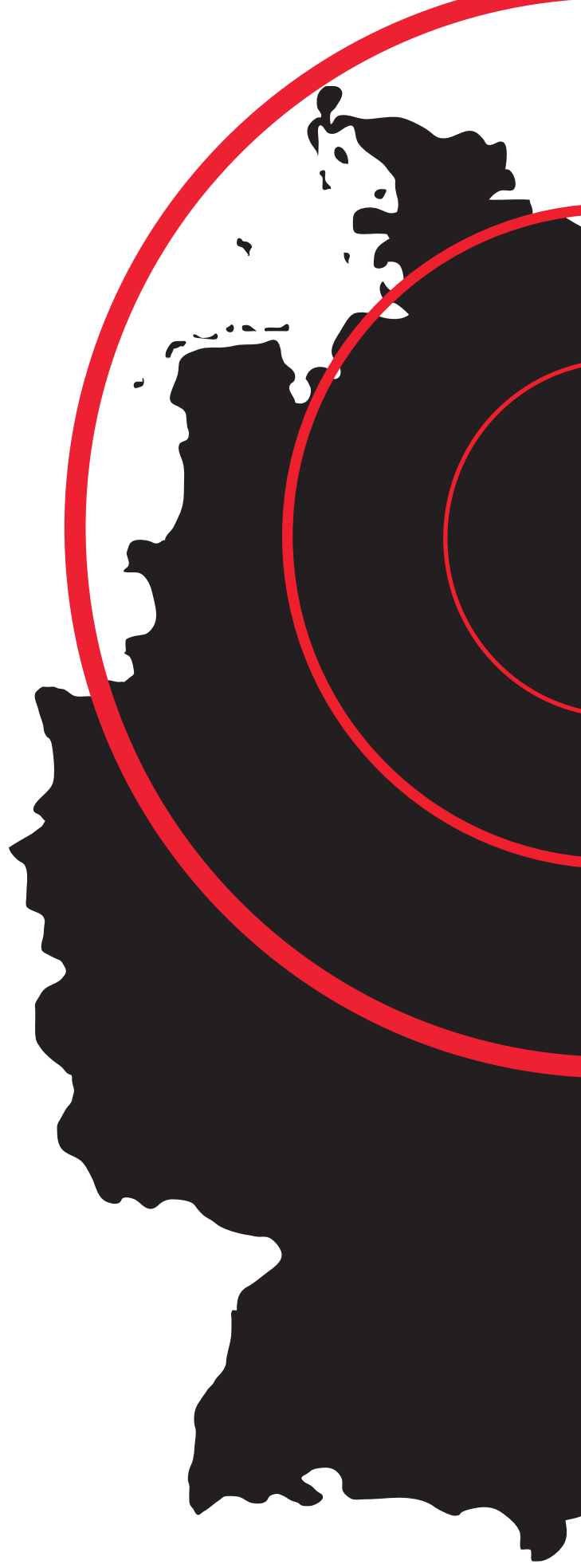
Reyes-Küpper rages at the weaponization of the crisis by those on the political right, including by the AfD. "People may stand there and criticize [Merkel], but when you ask them what they would have done, they have no answers. Imagine if Germany had closed its borders—we would have immediately been Nazis. We would have been compared to the Third Reich, and we would have been the terrible German nation."

Meier, though frustrated that the party has been hijacked by their more extreme elements, explained that "the AfD is made more extreme than it is through its portrayal in the media. The Left also has a bad reputation, but they have some good social policies." He would not be afraid to be ruled by a right-wing government—no more than he would be afraid to be ruled by the Left.

The younger generation often thinks differently: Svenja Küpper, a student who has become more active in politics in the wake of the 2017 federal elections, shared in an interview with *The Politic* that she votes mostly "in the hope that fewer seats go to the AfD," representing many young Germans who worry that their liberal tendencies are not being reflected in the increasingly radical politics of an aging population.

Although the overwhelming majority of the country would never vote for the AfD, the party has sparked debate among Germans. Some, like nurse Reyes-Küpper, are afraid. Indeed, she believes that the AfD embodies the most terrifying form of nationalism that Germany has seen since the Nazis.

HOLGER MEIER HAS ALWAYS been critical of politics. "There is no political party which has me completely convinced, and their ideologies are somewhat neutralized



when they come into power anyway." Almost by necessity, there is a disconnect between what politicians promise and what they can actually achieve. Recently, however, he has come to view this not as incidental disconnect, but rather as deliberate deception.

Meier is a bit of a renaissance man. He is a manager in water services and runs a small house brewery, through which he knows people from all walks of life. His family have been farmers in the area for generations. Although conversations in the brewery still focus on quotidian events like the harvest festivals, political debates now punctuate the talk. "Mercifully," Meier says, "people are starting to become more critical of classic politics."

He, along with many others, is dissatisfied with what he considers to be a stifling two-party system: "The big parties essentially stay in the middle, and concern themselves with the same topics, and have difficulty distinguishing themselves from each other."

Meier tells me, "politics are led by the media—and [the media's control] is only increasing. Although many people are quite against [Merkel's policy], their voices are cut out." According to Meier, the national broadcasters only present a positive view of refugees and Angela Merkel's policies. "The media would tell us that there are many highly-qualified people [among the refugees], but the truth is that they aren't necessarily the ones coming to rural Schaumburg."

Control of the narrative extended beyond TV and radio. Kornblum-Illgner tells me that "the discussion on domestic policy with the refugees and where the money goes and so on was the first time that social media played a really big role in public discussion." Social media created echo chambers of like-minded speech: "You can see when you talk to people whether they listen to national broadcasting or whether they live in their filtered bubbles."

National news outlets are no longer trusted for any information, as Meier, like many others, feels that "Politics and media try to steer us in a direction, even though they know perfectly well that it won't work in the way they're selling it." He says other news sources are necessary. "Of course, you should be critical of alternative media, but there are other thinkers and other writers which you can find only on the Internet and not in the daily newspapers."

"The idea of the established press lying to people is a right-wing ploy," Kornblum-Illgner says, "But at the beginning of the crisis, in one of the Bielefeld newspapers that my mother has a subscription to, every day they said something different. They had no clear line."

In Minden, a nearby city, there was discussion during one week in 2015 about whether the police should suppress information about the crisis in the interest of public safety. Even though they ultimately decided against it, the possibility of censorship vindicates the viewpoint that media and politicians are conspiring to sell people on bad politics. As Meier says, "If you're always lied to, you won't believe anything anymore."

HEIKE REYES-KÜPPER IS SITTING in her kitchen, sipping a cappuccino and wrapping dates in bacon. She tells me that these political discussions have become louder since the refugee crisis. "There has been a reversal of the direction of progress because of the refugee crisis."

Her husband, who has popped his head around the corner, frowns. Germans "aren't interested in politics," he says. "They're only interested in who it is that comes and goes." Most white Germans tiptoe around the possibility of racism, instead hurriedly assigning xenophobia to a different region, or focusing on the structural issues of the crisis. But the undercurrent is clear: It's racism hiding under the guise of political discussion.

"The hated figures," Kornblum-Illgner had explained to me several days earlier, "are young African men. Unmarried, of course."

The 2015 refugee crisis has been used by those unhappy with Merkel's policies to air their grievances. "Merkel's attitude," says Reyes-Küpper, "has always been a little too liberal, a little too socialist [for her party]." Her detractors scoff that she is the best Social Democrat Germany has ever had, a statement sometimes tied to the more right-wing claim that her politics are *linksversift*—besmirched by the left.

Through the refugee crisis, people have become more vocal about beliefs that do not align with the liberal, progressive mainstream. "People who wouldn't have dared to say anything because they believed that the majority was in favor [of liberal values] are now speaking up," Reyes-Küpper tells me.

Indeed, the AfD serves as an outlet for previously-hidden conservative voices. Germany today is far more progressive than it was in the '70s and '80s, or even the '90s. But "over the course of [building the] coalition," says Reyes-Küpper, "people were not [met] where they were." The AfD speaks to those people, and "somehow today we debate things that I didn't think we had to debate anymore. All this discussion about whether homosexuals should be able to marry—I thought we were through with that."

IT IS STILL UNCLEAR to many Germans if the politics of integration has failed. Public schools in Germany are excellent, but a concern that students from immigrant families slow down classroom progress due to the language barrier has led many white families who can afford it to move their children to private education.

In 2019, Meier led a school group on a tour of the waterworks where he works, and he was surprised to realize that every student in the class came from an immigrant background. There is no agreement, not even within parties, on the best path forward for Germany.

Meier tells me that interest in politics is a matter of character. Some people "are by nature interested in their [political] environment, while others... are simply interested in having their peace." He falls into the former category, voting in every election. Though he seems pleased by growing skepticism of the multi-party system, such questioning has been even more damaging to Germany.

"If I have to say why people are so strange sometimes," Kornblum-Illgner tells me, "it's fear." But she remains hopeful for a future in which young people who have had more contact with outside cultures are more understanding and less afraid. "Knowing my Vehlen people, I am sometimes so surprised at what terrible things they say, but I know—I know—if somebody they so hate was drowning in the Aue [River], they'd all jump in and get them out. They just don't have contact with what they're afraid of, so they have a good time enjoying their fear." Kornblum-Illgner's son attended a school whose students represented four nationalities. To young people, that contact with other cultures is normal.

The social ties in a village like Vehlen are much tighter than those in cities. Politics aren't off-limits exactly, but Kornblum-Illgner avoids the topic when she's not in the mood for long discussions. There is an understanding that public spaces are not intended for politics, because "you might spoil the host's party." When I asked whether she felt limited by this, cut off from the community based on her views, she told me no. The neighbor who she recalled "exploding" in the '90s was a good friend of hers.

She chooses to avoid discussions because they might become loud, but this is a "'village loud': People shout at each other, and then the next day is okay." Kornblum-Illgner explains this matter-of-factly: "If you don't agree with someone in a city, you go to a different pub. In the village, there is only one pub."

Lebanese First

Anti-corruption protests in Lebanon unite sectarian groups

BY **GALL SIGLER**

ON OCTOBER 17, 2019, Lebanon introduced a tax on talking. Although the Western-leaning government withdrew the tax on a series of internet services like WhatsApp phone calls within hours due to the public outcry on the streets of Beirut, it was already too late. The protests intensified, forcing the resignation of Prime Minister Saad Hariri and his cabinet less than two weeks later. Unsatisfied, protests continued, calling for systemic change in Lebanon's corrupt, sectarian politics.

What began as a minor protest in Beirut has led to riots across the country, with participants numbering in the hundreds of thousands. Proudly waving the Lebanese flag while blocking the streets of cities and towns, the protesters joyously danced and sang tunes ranging from "Baby Shark" to "Bella Ciao." Both young and old participated, eagerly contributing their individual skills and expertise to the grassroots movement.

Sectarian rhetoric—prevalent in Lebanese populism and demagogia—is strongly discouraged in the demonstrations. Protesters of diverse religions and sects chant "all of them means all of them," signaling their distrust in both political parties and sectarian elites alike. Some of them even wear "Joker" masks, invoking Gotham City as an analogy for the pervasive corruption and vast institutional inequality rotting Lebanon.

Alex Karam, a Maronite Christian; Iman Jaroudi '22, whose family is Sunni Muslim; and Melissa Koudjanian, an Armenian, are students of Lebanese descent living and studying abroad. These students all belong to different sects in Lebanon and live halfway across the world from the country yet are equally invested in and enthusiastic about the revolution. Just a few years ago, such a social consensus among sects would have been unimaginable. They represent how, in face of the degraded quality of life, there has emerged a climate of combined unity, optimism, and assertiveness.

"This is the first time we are seeing something like this in Lebanon," Melissa excitedly proclaimed. "As long as I can remember, nothing has come even close to this," Alex reaffirmed.

ALEX, WHO LEFT his Christian neighborhood in Beirut at 16 in search for better education, was studying for final exams at his boarding school in Japan when the protests broke out. He returned home in December to a country ready for a "really necessary" change. He enthusiastically joined the protests, singing the national anthem and waving the flag with his friends on the streets of his hometown.

The cascade of events in October followed by these unprecedented taxes—the straw that broke the camel's back—unleashed a tsunami of suppressed, long-held grievances.

Just three days before the initial mass mobilization, Lebanon's worried citizens watched their government ineffectively respond to wildfires spreading throughout the country's mountainous west. The country's fire-fighting vehicles were apparently out of commission due to poor maintenance, and the flames stopped only when neighboring countries Greece, Cyprus, and Turkey intervened.

Lebanon's eventful October also saw a new record in the country's worst economic crisis in decades. Lebanon faces crippling debt—the third largest in the world—and the government directs half its revenue to pay interest, a problem compounding upon their already inadequate public services and infrastructure.

"As long as I can remember, nothing has come even close to this."

Adding to a general feeling of hopelessness, youth unemployment in Lebanon reached 37 percent at the end of 2019, with more than a quarter of the Lebanese population living under the poverty line. It has been a widely-heard mantra in Lebanon that there is no point in going to university since there are no jobs.

Economic instability reached a new peak at the beginning of October when the value of the Lebanese pound diminished against the United States dollar for the first time in two decades. "The banks open at 9 am—I went at 7 am, and there was already a queue," recalled Alex, who rushed to withdraw U.S. dollars with his fellow citizens. This currency shock sparked panicked shortage scares, which may have ultimately brought people to the protests.

Alex sighed. "Everyone is on the streets, but they have no money," he said. Many stopped working in order to protest, he told me, proud of the citizens' dedication.

OVER THE PAST FEW YEARS, the Lebanese government has failed to deliver basic services. "I remember my grandma texting us that there are piles of trash in the middle of the street," recalled Iman Jaroudi '22, whose family still lives in Lebanon, in an interview with *The Politic*. Her relatives frequently lament the disturbing and humiliating mismanagement of Beirut. When Iman visits her family every few summers, she is struck by the sense of insecurity, chaos, and gradually increasing frustration towards the government.

Iman feels detached from politics on the ground. Her father moved to the United States from Lebanon in 1989, and she has lived in Kansas City, Kansas her whole life. She loves to talk about her repetitively-named hometown, but her identity has always stretched further. Meanwhile, her aunt, a professional graphic designer in Lebanon who believes in the need for reform, works closely with protest organizers on advertisements and lit-

erature and sends her regular updates.

Iman is proudly Lebanese, and the country plays a major role in conversations around the dinner table, but she's only been to the country four times—only three of which she can remember.

"You could tell something was bubbling beneath the surface," she said. She believes the uprising was an inevitable shock to the very foundations of Lebanon's politics, society, and identity. The political elite had finally "unleashed years of unrest," she said.

Lebanon is highly heterogeneous, composed of 18 distinct sects of Muslims and Christians and numerous other religious and ethnic minorities. Three decades ago, Lebanon fought a bloody civil war characterized by sectarian rivalry that ended with the Taif Accords. These agreements reaffirmed Lebanon's adherence to political confessionalism—the allocation of power in government proportionally based on ethno-sectarian criteria.

The speakers of Parliament, the Prime Minister, and the President are by law designated to be Sunni Muslim, Shi'a Muslim, and Maronite Christian respectively. The parliament's 124 seats are equally divided between Muslims and Christian, with general elections taking place only once every six years.

In theory, the sectarian system aims to promote coexistence and prevent the domination of one sect over the others in the Lebanese government. Until now, peaceful sectarian divides have characterized much of life in Lebanon, and calls for reform only remind the country of its traumatizing sectarian civil war that ended in 1989.

In practice, however, the system isn't so innocuous. Even the elections for parliament are inconsistent. Since 2009, Lebanon's parliament has voted three different times to postpone the elections due to concerns of instability until finally conducting them in 2018. In another undemocratic process, while Parliament is elected directly by the people, Parliament itself elects the

"The Lebanese people have united against those who they perceive as their true oppressors: the political elite that has controlled the country since the end of the three-decade civil war.

president for a six-year term. And even the power of the parliament is disputable: While representing all political parties, Hezbollah, a U.S.-denoted terrorist organization, is believed to be pulling the strings. Hezbollah is holding "Lebanon's security and prosperity hostage," explained Rachel Mikeska, a spokeswoman at the American embassy in Lebanon, in an interview with the *New York Times*.

In the foreground, major parties, such as the Sunni "Future Movement," are allegedly in control, but these parties merely pay lip service to opposing Hezbollah's influence, and are perceived by the Lebanese people as highly corrupt and self-interested. "They are trying to manipulate us for their personal gain," asserted Iman.

Many of the protesters are calling for a complete dismantling of the sectarian system, direct election of the president, and the abolishment of the sect quotas. "It is long overdue," said Iman. "This system cannot hold up in the 21st century."

The Lebanese people have united against those who they perceive as their true oppressors: the political elite that has controlled the country since the end of the three-decade civil war. Not the Christians against the Muslims. Not the Shiites against the Sunnis. "At the end of the day, we are all Lebanese," Iman said.

Not the Christians against the Muslims.

Not the Shiites against the Sunnis."

NOW FIVE MONTHS INTO the upheaval, the movement is only gaining momentum. "The motivation for the protest, I don't think it has gotten weaker," Melissa, who has proudly watched history unfold in her home country from her dorm at the University of British Columbia, said in an interview with *The Politic*.

Lebanon's complicated political system, coupled with bitter and long-held sectarian divides, prevented any united movement against the ruling political elite in the past. Melissa lived in Lebanon until she was 16 and watched united peoples on TV rise up in neighboring countries while Lebanon remained mired in political stasis.

"It is not just the WhatsApp tax. They had it coming," Melissa said, referring to the government's short-sightedness in proposing these steep taxes. The collective shift of economic stability from something socially realized to a tangible reality had a shocking impact on Lebanese everyday life. "It became more personal when your family is struggling," Melissa said.

In response to public outcry, on January 31 the Parliament elected a new cabinet composed of technocrats endorsed by Hezbollah, promising to resolve Lebanon's economic troubles. The protest movement immediately rejected their legitimacy, and within hours, the streets were full again. As a Lebanese blogger wrote, while the new cabinet has financial expertise, "the other half of the demand is that they be politically independent."

Or as Melissa put it: The cabinet is "absolute crap."

Lebanon's government is currently ranked 137th out of 180 on the Corruption Perception Index, a measure of government transparency."If you ask anyone, it's the same-old, same-old. Everyone is corrupt, and we don't need to know anything more," Melissa admitted.

As reported by the *New York Times* in 2019, the private company Eden Bay seized one of Lebanon's last public beaches. Not coincidentally, a relative of the former Shiite speaker of the Parliament was the owner and made a killing from the sale. Lebanon is also infamous for its inconsistent electricity services—concerns the government has barely responded to, ostensibly because utility company producers have lobbied the government to prevent reforms. Also unsurprisingly, the leader of the Druz political party, a religiously distinct sect constituting five percent of Lebanon's population, owns a firm importing fuel that powers the generators.

Perhaps as important is what the government has not done. While

the country has been running out of hard currency and relying almost completely on imports for all of its products, there are 25 trillion cubic feet of natural gas in Lebanon's territorial shelf waiting to be extracted.

"Even if this new government tries to take Lebanon out of the deep financial crisis it is in, I don't know if the people will stop protesting," says Melissa. Lebanon is trying to redefine itself by developing a more collective and inclusive national identity. Instead of preventing societal rifts, the sectarian system has exacerbated other divides. Before, "although everyone criticized the government, everyone was stuck to their sects and political parties." Now, for the first time in Lebanon's history, they're subscribing to another belongingness paradigm: the people versus the political elite.

Melissa believes that her generation is more ready to move forward from Lebanon's troubling past toward a shared Lebanese identity. "With the younger generation, things are different," she said, pointing at increased secularization and the fading memory of the civil war.

"I live in a country with 50 percent Muslims. I did not have a friend who is Muslim," Melissa said of her experience before the protests began. In the past, according to Melissa, such cohesiveness between the different sects was nonexistent. "Although everyone criticized the government, everyone was stuck to their sects and political parties," she said. That has started to change. With the Lebanese flag replacing the appeal of the propaganda of political parties, the protesters are united against the elite, not against one another.

Now, for the first time in Lebanon's history, they're subscribing to another belongingness paradigm: the people versus the political elite.

FOR THESE STUDENTS, the protests are about more than economic interests; they are about national aspirations. To them, this diverse, grassroots effort is why Lebanon's protests are different from the Arab Spring and other revolutions and why the only remedy will be a structural change and the dismantling of the illegitimate political elite.

"There was no urge or that excitement," says Melissa, referring to the failed protests of the Arab Spring, which hazily colored her childhood memories.

The combination of worsening economic conditions in the foreground and the underlying anger gradually built up over the corruption enhanced the sense of national belongingness observed by Melissa, Alex, and Iman. Alex is optimistic that his status as a Maronite Christian will not isolate him for much longer. "I have always identified myself as a Lebanese first," he says.

CW: racial and sexual violence



DO NO HARM

reflecting on a legacy of pain for black women and girls in the United States

BY **ISIUWA OMOIGUI**

IT'S NOT DIFFICULT to imagine: under fluorescent lights, the five men sitting down in sleek, comfortable office chairs in a building in Raleigh and reviewing the facts of the case. The "feebleminded" black girl was irredeemable, they thought. A life of promiscuity would naturally be her fate unless they, the Eugenics Board of North Carolina, intervened.

Molested, kidnapped, and pregnant from a rape several months earlier, Elaine Riddick received no sympathy. It was 1968 in a segregated North Carolina town. She was 14 years old, living with her grandmother Maggie Woodward.

Woodward, who had never received a formal education, was given two choices when the social worker sent by the Board showed up at their door to take away her granddaughter: She could lose her welfare benefits, or she could mark X on an ambiguous consent form. As with so many other cases, the will of the Eugenics Board prevailed.

State doctors strapped Riddick to a table, delivered her baby, and proceeded with the tubal ligation immediately after. They anesthetized her. Sliced her open. Located her fallopian tubes. Burned them and stitched her up afterward. While the stitches eventually healed, Riddick's anguish did not.

She only found out when five years later, she tried to start a family of her own. Test after test after test, the reason for her infertility was still a bold question mark. Her doctors performed laparoscopic surgery to search for the answer. Again, they sliced her open. Under the harsh white light of the surgical lamp, they saw butchery. With a steely resolve, she said in an interview with *The Politic*, "The doctors at the county hospital [in 1968], because of my race, didn't care how they did the surgery. They so severely damaged me that I eventually had to have a total hysterectomy."

Degraded and humiliated, Riddick, with help from the American Civil Liberties Union, took her case to court in Chapel Hill in 1981. After a mere 30 minutes of deliberation, the nearly all-white jury sided with the state. In their eyes, no one violated Elaine Riddick. The Supreme Court refused to even hear the case. Indeed, in 1927, the Court had officially legitimated forced sterilization in *Buck vs. Bell*. The case still stands.

"I felt like I was being punished all over again, first by the rapist and then by the state of North Carolina.... They had taken away my womanhood," Riddick recalled in an interview with *The Politic*. "What could little boys and girls as young as eight do to cause their government to want to castrate them, except for being born poor while black?"

VIOLATING THE REPRODUCTIVE autonomy of black women was not a 20th-century invention. As Professor Alexandra Stern, director of the Sterilization and Social Justice Lab at the University of Michigan, explained in an interview with *The Politic*, "Slavery and the white supremacist treatment of black women's bodies set a framework for reproductive injustice that continued past 1865 and into the Jim Crow era."

Dating back to slavery, portrayals of women differed along racial lines. White women were paragons of modesty and purity, while black women and girls were Jezebels—alluring African-American women valued purely for their sexuality. Even in American material culture from emancipation to the 1950s, quotidian items like ashtrays, postcards, and drinking glasses depicted black women with minimal clothing and minimal sexual restraint. Today, research suggests that black women are still more often oversexualized than white women in mainstream media.

These characterizations have had other horrific consequences throughout history. In courtrooms across the South, white men stood accused of raping black women, judges and juries delivered the same verdict again and again: not guilty. From emancipation through most of the 20th century, not one white Southern man was convicted of raping or attempting to rape a black woman.

The oversexualization of black

women is also seen through the thousands of state-sanctioned eugenic sterilization practices that occurred during the 20th century. Specifically, in North Carolina, notions of the black population as a parasitic influence on the body politic informed the state's intense focus on regulating the reproduction of girls as young as 12.

The door to the past is wide open. As the Center for Investigative Reporting documented in 2010, two women's prisons in California signed 150 pregnant women up for permanent sterilization after childbirth without following state approval procedures.

In an interview with NPR in 2013, former inmate Kimberly Jeffrey said she resisted the pressure to be sterilized even within the operating room as she was being sedated. But her rights as an autonomous human being didn't matter. What mattered to the state of California was her status as a member of a supposedly undesirable group. Carceral spaces today predominantly contain those historically targeted for sterilization: the poor and people of color.

There may not be hope for an end to these horrific practices. In response to the recent incidents in California, Riddick replied, "I am not surprised."

IT'S NOT DIFFICULT to imagine: Under the blinding fluorescent hospital lights, Minnie Relf sighing calmly, remembering what the doctors had told her. Her daughters would get "some shots," that was all. Her eyes scanned the pages and then she marked X. Minnie Lee and Mary Alice Relf, her two daughters, were poor, black, and lived in public housing. The state didn't think twice about sterilizing them.

Alabamian doctors and legislators were convinced that the girls—just 12 and 14—were too likely to impose a burden on state resources by having babies. That day in 1973, it didn't matter to the federally funded Montgomery Family Planning Clinic that the girls were themselves children, or that their parents didn't give informed consent for the procedure. In his testimony before a Senate Health Subcommittee in 1973, their father Lonnie stated, "I didn't want it done, and I'm still upset."

The Relf family sued the clinic and the federal government for $1 million worth of damages. In July 1973, Massachusetts Senator Edward Kennedy invited Lonnie to testify to the subcommittee to help pass a bill he authored to improve protective systems for human research subjects. In light of the national outcry caused by the Relf sisters' case and the Tuskegee Syphilis Study, Senator Kennedy's bill suggested the creation of the National Commission for the Protection of Human Subjects of Biomedical and Behavioral Research, catalyzing debate about coercion and informed consent. President Nixon signed it into law on July 12, 1974.

The Relf sisters were only two of thousands of misinformed, medically exploited black patients in a legacy extending to the 1970s. Throughout the United States, 65,000 people were sterilized. From 1933 to the 1970s, during the program's heyday, the Eugenics Commission of North Carolina alone carried out 7,686 sterilizations, justifying them as measures to stop "mentally deficient persons" from reproducing. After 1960, 99 percent of those sterilized were women. The promiscuous, lazy, unfit, and sexually uncontrollable had to be contained. By the late 1960s, 60 percent of sterilization victims were young African-American women, even though they comprised only a quarter of the North Carolinian population.

Criminals, the disabled, and people with mental illness were also in the crosshairs of the state's mission to limit the reproduction of the unfit. In North Carolina, the language of mental uselessness was a discursive tactic to refract racism through the obfuscating terminology of eugenics. To eliminate future recipients of welfare, the recipients of which included a growing number of black women, was to eliminate growing financial burdens on the state.

"THIS IS NOT STERILIZATION," Tony

We see and feel the painful legacies of slavery all around us.

Riddick, Elaine's son, explained to the North Carolina Governor's Eugenics Compensation Task Force in 2011. "This is genocide." His mother agreed: "This is a depopulation process. They don't want black people here. They don't see us as human."

In 2012, North Carolina became the first state to compensate the victims of mass sterilization programs and offered $50,000 to each living survivor and funding for their mental health services. Virginia is the only other state that has compensated victims—they offered half of that amount. Seven out of the 33 states that engaged in mass sterilization programs issued public apologies.

To survivors, apologies and compensation are meaningless. Riddick received $43,000, and she sees it as a slap in the face.

Questions about whether eugenic sterilization programs like North Carolina's rise to the level of genocide still linger. In studying the political economy of North Carolina's program, William A. Darity Jr., Professor of Public Policy in the Sanford School at Duke University, found that there was an explicit intent to eliminate the black population in North Carolina. Even when accounting for the sterilizations of people deemed "feebleminded"—which the state used to mean biologically unfit due to mental health characteristics—Darity noted that eugenic sterilizations increased with the black unemployed population. He calls the program a "campaign of black genocide."

Stern refrained from labeling these programs as such. "When does something meet the threshold of genocide?" she queried. "That is a debate that we should have." Article 2, Section D of the UN's Convention on the Prevention and Punishment of the Crime of Genocide stipulates that genocide must include two elements: the intent to destroy and a form of physical destruction. There must be *dolus specialis*, a proven intent to physically destroy a national, ethnic, religious, or racial group, which is associated with the existence of a state or organizational policy, but genocide during peacetime is a rare, but real, possibility. The physical element can include "imposing measures intended to prevent births within that [racial, national, ethnic, or religious] group."

Stern cited cases like the sterilization of hundreds of thousands of Native American women on reservations by the Indian Health Service as a guide for future discussion on the issue. In a country founded on a bedrock of settler colonialism and anti-blackness, violence isn't limited to acts of deadly aggression.

As Nial Ramirez, a woman sterilized in Washington County in 1965, put it in an interview with the *Winston-Salem Journal*: "If you were poor, black, and had nothing, they wanted to get rid of you. They wanted to get rid of your kids."

In 2002, John Railey and a team of reporters at the *Winston Salem Journal* were the first to gain access to records that exposed the inner workings of North Carolina's sterilization program in 2002. It was not the North Carolina he had grown up in, which he knew as one of the only states in the South with relatively peaceful racial integration efforts. Like many other North Carolinians, he was dismayed by what his state had done. "We think this stuff happens in other countries, but it happens here," he lamented. "Nazi Germany modeled its sterilization program on North Carolina's. Morality has nothing to do with legality," he said in an interview with *The Politic*.

I THOUGHT THEY were complimenting me. The words they used were innocuous. They seemed sincere. "You look so grown for your age."

I was a child then. I didn't know what made me look older to them. Nothing happened to me. But other black girls who look "grown" aren't as lucky. The teenage girl violently thrown across a classroom by a South Carolina school resource officer in 2016 wasn't as lucky. Neither was the 11-year-old girl tasered by police for allegedly shoplifting groceries in Cincinnati in 2018. If those girls were white, the altercations might have gone differently. Guilty until proven innocent, we are robbed of the leeway given to our white peers. In viewing us as "grown" and stripping us of our childhood, society holds us to the standard of adults, placing undue responsibility on us for our actions.

As the Georgetown Law Center on Poverty and Inequality reported in 2008, "compared to white girls of the same age (i.e. age range of five to 14), adults perceive that black girls need less protection, know more about adult topics, and know more about sex." Yet they are seen as too childlike and promiscuous to exercise reproductive autonomy over their bodies.

Mistreatment at the hands of police and school resource officers differs greatly from the experiences of Minnie Relf and so many others, but the same underlying principles unite them. For black women and girls, the past is ever-present: We see and feel the painful legacies of slavery all around us.

As a black woman and Yale student, I am electrified by course options like "African Literature in the World" and "Introduction to Ethnicity, Race, and Migration." Yet the specter of a different Yale than the one we know looms over us.

The same classrooms and lecture halls that house enriching discussions about empowering minority communities today were once spaces in which eugenics was lauded. The Yale Alumni Magazine notes that in 1921, famed Yale economics professor Irving Fisher spoke animatedly of the "race suicide among the well-to-do classes that meant that their places will speedily by taken by the unintelligent, uneducated, and inefficient."

Not far from the New Haven Green, the American Eugenics Society's office stood, supported by numerous Yale faculty. Yale president James R. Angell, celebrated football coach Walter Camp '80, primatologist Rob-

ert Yerkes, and Yale School of Medicine dean Milton Winternitz all strongly defended the cause.

Stern said, "All the Ivies were heavy into eugenics in the first part of the 20th century.... Institutions can be at the cutting edge where these kinds of knowledge are legitimated. You can see from the historical record that eugenics would not have thrived the way it did in the United States without universities." In turn, we must critically engage with the kinds of knowledge that educational institutions perpetuate. These horrific injustices continued because people didn't ask questions. People trusted authorities to distinguish between right and wrong. Horrors like this can go on. And if we don't step up, they will.

Fisher and his peers may not have known Minnie Lee Relf or Elaine Riddick, but the women felt the impacts of the views he so proudly espoused.

IN THE HISTORIC African American fight for racial equality, black men are often cast as the protagonists of the struggle, while the distinct oppression of black women is a marginalized narrative. Look no further than the horrors experienced by Elaine Riddick for evidence.

Riddick's tragedy motivated her to start building a sanctuary shelter for youth at risk, abandoned babies, chemically dependent children, and victims of human trafficking. Now the president of the Rebecca Project for Justice, she advocates for young women and girls in the United States and Africa who have suffered from physical, sexual, and medical violence. But her own pain will not subside.

"I still get teary-eyed. I still cry.... You just don't get over stuff like that," Riddick said, her voice trembling.

Historically, black bodies bore the weight of advancement in medicine. Dr. Marion Sims, the father of American gynecology, performed painful, experimental procedures on enslaved women without anesthesia because he believed that African Americans did not feel pain. To this day, false beliefs of biological difference between black and white people color the way medical students and residents assess and treat black patients' pain.

Ultimately, our lives are at stake. Faced with racial disparities that leave us three to four times more likely to die during or after childbirth than our white peers, black women contend with a healthcare system that never favored us. Even outside the programs, doctors took it upon themselves to sterilize women on welfare with more than two to three children. Programs of mass sterilization throughout the nation are evidence of deeply entrenched medical racism.

With their right hands raised, doctors swore to do no harm. Yet, harm has been done. Racism's intersecting hands reach deep into our lives. And they hurt.

A Conversation with

Admiral Mike Mullen

On Don't Ask, Don't Tell; the Obama administration; and the rules of intervention

Admiral Michael Mullen served as the 17th Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff under Presidents Bush and Obama. He previously served in both the Vietnam and Gulf wars and was the 28th Chief of Naval Operations from 2005-2007.

BY **PAUL ROTMAN**

YOU WERE CHAIRMAN OF THE JOINT CHIEFS WHEN THE DON'T ASK, DON'T TELL POLICY ENDED. WHAT WAS THAT PROCESS LIKE?

There hadn't been much work on it since 1993 when the policy was put in place. What I did find on my own is that it's important to remind people of the baseline: The average age of any military unit is 21 years old, and I couldn't find anyone under 30 years old that thought it was a very important issue at all.

Young people had been both living with and accepting of gays through their lives. That was not the case obviously with people who had been around a lot longer. This was nothing the civilian leadership could do without the support from the military.

It was a pretty easy statement for me to make at that point because I believed it was a real turning point.

THERE'S A FAMOUS PHOTO OF YOU, PRESIDENT OBAMA, VICE PRESIDENT BIDEN, AND SECRETARY CLINTON WATCHING THE BIN LADEN RAID IN 2011. WHAT WAS GOING THROUGH YOUR MIND AT THAT SPECIFIC MOMENT?

I ran into [the photographer, Pete Souza] a couple of years ago. I asked [about the photo] because I didn't [remember the moment], to see if he could find the timestamp. He told me he took over a thousand pictures that night. What was going on exactly at that moment, I'm not sure.

The photo is so famous...[because] it captures the intensity of the moment. We all understood it was really critical to the nation and to the world.

YOU'VE MENTIONED THAT THE KILLING OF SOLEMEINI WAS JUSTIFIED. WHAT MAKES ESCALATION JUSTIFIED?

It was very clear that there was a constant, continuous build-up over many months with respect to the US and Iran. We haven't had a communications link with Iran since 1979, so we have no way to really exchange ideas. If we get into a situation with Iran, having no way to communicate, the likelihood it comes out the way we want it is I think pretty low.

I think we were closer to war than we realized. Fortunately, the powers that be made decisions which backed us away from it after the Solemeini killing. [General Milley] said it was exquisite intelligence. And by virtue of that, I still think he's a risky target, but a legitimate target.

WHAT ONE PIECE OF ADVICE WOULD YOU GIVE CONGRESS AND THE PRESIDENT ABOUT FOREIGN TROOP DEPLOYMENT?

It has been far too easy to get into conflicts. We need to be much more careful about where we deploy, when we deploy, and how we deploy our troops. Diligence about that would be my highest priority.

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The MacMillan Center produces *The MacMillan Report*, an Internet show that showcases Yale faculty in international and areas studies and their research in a one-on-one interview format. Webisodes can be viewed at macmillanreport.yale.edu.

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